The Bespoke Ride

Ultra-wealthy Indians are going to great lengths to make their cars stand out. The aim: Make their vehicles an extension of their personality

BY **KARAN DHAR**

FOR INDIA'S SUPER rich, the pinnacle of luxury and performance is no longer simply buying a Rolls-Royce or a Ferrari but turning them into a piece that tells their story. Jet-setting ultra-wealthy Indians are even travelling to Goodwood in the UK (home to the Rolls-Royce) or Maranello in Italy (Ferrari) to configure their cars to reflect their passions, memories, or personal milestones.

So, for a Rolls-Royce customer, dealership is only the first leg in the car-buying journey. Those who are unable to travel to the factory in the UK visit one of the five Rolls-Royce Private Offices around the world to design their dream car.

"Some clients enjoy the opportunity to come to the private office to sit with a designer and create something special. Some come to Goodwood to get a sense of what our craftspeople are capable of doing," Julian Jenkins, Director of Sales & Brand, Rolls-Royce Motor Cars, tells *BT*.

Some prefer visiting the Rolls-Royce factory in Goodwood. "We engage with them through the summer months. Our clients are in a relaxed state of mind as they have more time, and are more creative as a result," says Jenkins.

Every bespoke commission starts with a discussion with clients. And brands are happy to oblige. "We listen. We don't say no," says Jenkins. The carmaker says no only for legal or regulatory reasons.

About 20-30% Rolls-Royce customers in India opt for significant bespoke commissions, says Jenkins. Some spend as much as the price of the car, he adds. A bespoke commission takes at least a year. The marque's more ambitious Coach-build creations can take four-five years, says Jenkins.

THE GOLDEN TOUCH

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- SOME SPEND AS MUCH AS THE PRICE OF THE CAR ON THE UPGRADE
- INDIAN CUSTOMERS START CUSTOMISATION WITH COLOUR AND STITCHING
- THE LONG WAITING TIME GIVES CUSTOMERS TIME TO REVISIT THEIR REQUESTS